

One the most controversial TV reports was broadcast in 1965, when CBS correspondent Morley Safer accompanied US Marines on a search-and-destroy mission. Rather than rooting out Viet Cong guerrillas, the Marines evacuated and burned an entire peasant village: images that did not play well with the American public. Larry Burrows's evocative photos for *Life* magazine depicted the plight of ordinary GIs in the face of horrible battlefield conditions.

“Vietnam was the first war ever fought without any censorship.”

GENERAL WILLIAM WESTMORELAND IN *TIME* MAGAZINE, APRIL 5, 1982

Coverage after Tet

The Pentagon's policy of giving reporters extraordinary access would backfire in the wake of the Tet Offensive in 1968. Despite claims by American leadership that Tet was a US and ARVN victory, TV images, photos, and stories about the offensive seemed to prove otherwise. Witnessing carnage in the streets of every major South Vietnamese city, the media now painted a picture of looming defeat.

The Tet Offensive radically altered the perception of the war by media stars back home, many of whom had a great influence over American public opinion. CBS anchorman Walter Cronkite, venturing to Vietnam in the aftermath of the Tet Offensive, aired a scathing report on the state of the war effort. “We have been too often disappointed by the optimism of the American leaders, both in Vietnam and Washington, to have faith any longer in the silver linings they find in the darkest clouds,” Cronkite declared.

President Johnson, upon viewing the report, reportedly quipped that “If I’ve lost Cronkite, I’ve lost Middle America.” The conversion of Cronkite and other media gatekeepers from ambivalent onlookers to antiwar advocates was a major blow to the American effort in Vietnam.